

Based on the sources provided, the five-step process for writing a winning cover letter (specifically for Upwork) is designed to hook clients and demonstrate your specific value to their business.

Step 1: Find the Best Jobs

The first step is being selective to avoid wasting "connects" on low-probability jobs 1, 2.

- **Check Activity:** Look at the "activity on this job" section. You are more likely to be noticed if there are **fewer than 15 proposals** already submitted 2.
- **Recency:** Speed is important; the faster you send a proposal, the better your chances 2. However, do not apply if the client hasn't checked the job posting in **over a week**, as it may expire without the client hiring anyone 3, 4.

Step 2: Hook the Client

Clients only see the **first two sentences** of your cover letter before deciding whether to open it, making these the most important part of your proposal 4.

- **Personalization:** Use the client's name if you can find it in their feedback history; otherwise, use a professional greeting like "Hi" or "Hello" 5.
- **Client Perspective:** Show immediately that you have read the job description and understand their goals 5. For example, a video editor might hook a client by explaining how their style can increase views and revenue 6.

Step 3: Show Specific Examples of Work

The samples you provide are often the most influential factor in a client's decision to hire 7, 8.

- **Relevance is Key:** Only include work that matches exactly what the client needs. If a client wants a finance video editor, do not show them a fast-paced gaming reel 9, 10.
- **Be Concise:** Choose **three to five** of your best work samples that align with the job description 10.
- **Utilize Features:** Use Upwork's "profile highlights" to showcase relevant work history, portfolios, or certifications 7.

Step 4: Showcase Your Value

Re-read the job description to identify exactly how you can add value to the client's business and make yourself stand out from the competition 8.

- **List Key Points:** Briefly list a few specific things you can offer that address the client's primary needs 8, 11.
- **Thinking Like a Client:** Focus on the outcomes the client actually wants rather than just listing your skills 8.

Step 5: Use a Call to Action (CTA)

The final step is to encourage the client to take the next step by suggesting a meeting 11.

- **Request an Intro Call:** Ask for a quick **10-minute introduction call** 11. This is highly effective because it allows both parties to see if they are a good fit and often leads to an immediate job offer 11, 12.
- **Professional Reputation:** The intro call also helps you vet the client to ensure they are someone you can work well with, which protects your ability to earn five-star reviews 12.